高考那一年

一张志愿表上的两个梦想

The Year of the Gaokao

Two dreams on one application form

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 5 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 每年六月七日的早上，河南[1]安阳[2]会变得特别安静。路上的车开得很慢，考场[3]附近站满了家长。这一天，全国一千多万名高中生走进考场，参加高考[4]。陈静[5]就是其中的一个。她的故事，要从前一年的九月说起。

九月

2 九月一日，陈静上了高三[6]。教室还是那间教室，同桌还是方圆[7]，可是大家都感觉得到，一切都不一样了。班主任[8]王老师走进教室，第一句话就是："从今天开始，你们只有一件事，就是高考。"教室里没有一个人说话。陈静低着头，在本子上画了一个小小的图案，那是甲骨文[9]里的"人"字。

1 河南 *Hénán* Henan Province
2 安阳 *Ānyáng* Anyang, a city in Henan
3 考场 *kǎochǎng* examination site
4 高考 *gāokǎo* national college entrance exam
5 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
6 高三 *gāosān* final year of senior high school
7 方圆 *Fāng Yuán* Fang Yuan
8 班主任 *bānzhǔrèn* homeroom teacher
9 甲骨文 *jiǎgǔwén* oracle bone script

Every year, on the morning of the seventh of June, Anyang in Henan grows unusually quiet. Cars drive slowly, and the streets near the exam sites are packed with parents. On this day more than ten million high school students across the country walk into exam halls to sit the gaokao. Chen Jing was one of them. Her story begins in the September of the year before. 1

September

On the first of September, Chen Jing began her final year of high school. The classroom was the same, and her deskmate was still Fang Yuan, but everyone could feel that everything had changed. Their homeroom teacher, Mr Wang, walked in, and the first thing he said was: "From today on, you have only one thing to do, and that is the gaokao." Not one person in the room spoke. Chen Jing kept her head down and drew a tiny figure in her notebook: the character for "person" in oracle bone script. 2

3 陈静[1]是个安静的女孩，成绩不错，但不是班里最好的那几个。她不爱说话，老师提问的时候，她的声音总是很小。很少有人知道，她心里藏[2]着一个梦想：她想学考古[3]。

4 这个梦想是从小时候开始的。安阳[4]是殷墟[5]所在的地方，三千多年前，商朝[6]的都城[7]就在这里。陈静七岁那年，爷爷带她去殷墟参观。她站在玻璃前面，看着那些刻在龟甲[8]和牛骨[9]上的字，很久都不愿意走。爷爷告诉她："这些字叫甲骨文[10]，是现在能看到的最早的汉字之一。"陈静问："是谁把它们找出来的？"爷爷笑着说："考古的人。他们在土里找历史。"

5 从那以后，她看了很多关于考古的书和电视节目，可是从来没有跟妈妈说过。

1 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
2 藏 *cáng* to hide
3 考古 *kǎogǔ* archaeology
4 安阳 *Ānyáng* Anyang, a city in Henan
5 殷墟 *Yīnxū* Yinxu, ruins of the late Shang capital
6 商朝 *Shāngcháo* Shang dynasty
7 都城 *dūchéng* capital city
8 龟甲 *guījiǎ* tortoise shell
9 牛骨 *niúgǔ* ox bone
10 甲骨文 *jiǎgǔwén* oracle bone script

Chen Jing was a quiet girl with good marks, but she was not one of the very best in the class. She did not like to talk, and when a teacher called on her, her voice was always small. Few people knew that she kept a dream hidden inside her: she wanted to study archaeology. 3

The dream went back to her childhood. Anyang is where Yinxu lies; more than three thousand years ago, the capital of the Shang dynasty stood here. The year Chen Jing was seven, her grandfather took her to visit Yinxu. She stood in front of the glass, looking at the characters carved on tortoise shells and ox bones, and for a long time she refused to leave. Her grandfather told her, "These characters are called oracle bone script. They are among the earliest Chinese characters we can still see today." Chen Jing asked, "Who found them?" Her grandfather smiled. "Archaeologists. They look for history in the earth." 4

From then on she read many books and watched many TV programmes about archaeology, but she never said a word about it to her mother. 5

5 妈妈是市医院的护士，工作很辛苦。爸爸在广州[1]打工，一年只回来两三次。妈妈常说："妈妈这辈子没机会了，你一定要考个好大学，学医或者学金融[2]。工作稳定，谁都看得起[3]。"每次听到这句话，陈静[4]都只是点点头。

6 方圆[5]跟她正好相反，说话很快，笑起来声音很大。她们从高一[6]开始就是同桌，方圆是唯一知道陈静秘密的人。第一次听说的时候，方圆吃惊地问："你真的想去挖[7]土啊？""不是挖土，"陈静认真地说，"是找东西，找三千年前的人留下的东西。"方圆想了想，说："听起来挺有意思的。哪怕全世界都觉得你奇怪，我也支持你。"

1 广州 *Guǎngzhōu* Guangzhou
2 金融 *jīnróng* finance
3 看得起 *kàndeqǐ* to respect
4 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
5 方圆 *Fāng Yuán* Fang Yuan
6 高一 *gāoyī* first year of senior high school
7 挖 *wā* to dig

Her mother was a nurse at the city hospital, and her work was hard. Her father worked in Guangzhou and came home only two or three times a year. Her mother often said, "I never had the chance in my life. You must get into a good university and study medicine or finance. With a stable job, everyone will look up to you." Every time she heard this, Chen Jing just nodded. 5

Fang Yuan was her exact opposite: she talked fast and laughed loudly. They had shared a desk since their first year, and Fang Yuan was the only one who knew Chen Jing's secret. When she first heard about it, Fang Yuan asked in surprise, "You really want to go and dig in the dirt?" "Not dig in the dirt," Chen Jing said seriously. "Look for things, things left behind by people three thousand years ago." Fang Yuan thought about it and said, "Sounds pretty interesting. Even if the whole world thinks you're strange, I'll still back you." 6

墙上的倒计时[†]

7 十月初，教室后面的墙上挂起了一块倒计时牌，上面用红色的大字写着："距离高考[‡]还有 245 天"。每天早上，值日的同学都会把数字改一下：244，243，242 ... ... 王老师说："看着数字一天天变小，大家不免会紧张，这很正常。紧张说明你们在乎。"

8 高三[§]的生活很简单，也很累。早上六点起床，六点半到教室上早自习[¶]，晚上十点下了晚自习[*]才回家。课间休息的十分钟，有人在桌子上睡觉，有人还在做题。每个人的桌子上都堆满了试卷和复习资料，高得能挡住脸。陈静[#]每天都学到半夜。妈妈下班回来，总会给她热一杯牛奶，轻轻地放在桌子上，再轻轻地关上门。

† 倒计时 *dàojìshí* countdown
‡ 高考 *gāokǎo* national college entrance exam
§ 高三 *gāosān* final year of senior high school
¶ 早自习 *zǎozìxí* early morning self-study
* 晚自习 *wǎnzìxí* evening self-study
\# 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing

The Countdown on the Wall

In early October a countdown board went up on the wall at the back of 7
the classroom. In big red characters it said: "245 days to the gaokao." Every morning the student on duty changed the number: 244, 243, 242... Mr Wang said, "Watching the number get smaller every day, it's natural that you'll feel nervous. That's normal. Being nervous shows that you care."

Life in the final year was simple, and exhausting. Up at six, in the classroom 8
by half past six for morning self-study, and home only after evening self-study ended at ten. In the ten-minute breaks between classes, some slept on their desks and others kept working on exercises. Every desk was piled with exam papers and revision books, stacked high enough to hide a face. Chen Jing studied until midnight every day. When her mother came home from work, she would always warm a glass of milk for her, set it down gently on the desk, and gently close the door again.

9 看着墙上的数字一天天变小，陈静[†]也不免紧张起来。有时候她躺在床上，怎么也睡不着，脑子里全是公式和单词。她常常想：要是考不好，怎么办？要是考好了，妈妈让她学医，她又该怎么办？

10 有一天晚自习[‡]，方圆[§]递给她一张小纸条，上面写着："别忘了你的殷墟[¶]！"下面还画了一个甲骨文[*]的"目"字，像一只眼睛，画得一点儿也不像。陈静看了，忍不住笑出了声。这是那个月她第一次笑。

模拟[#]考试

11 十二月，全市进行了第一次模拟考试。

† 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
‡ 晚自习 *wǎnzìxí* evening self-study
§ 方圆 *Fāng Yuán* Fang Yuan
¶ 殷墟 *Yīnxū* Yinxu, ruins of the late Shang capital
* 甲骨文 *jiǎgǔwén* oracle bone script
\# 模拟 *mónǐ* mock, simulated

Watching the number on the wall shrink day by day, Chen Jing could not help growing nervous too. Sometimes she lay in bed and could not fall asleep however hard she tried, her head full of formulas and vocabulary. She often wondered: what if she did badly? And if she did well and her mother made her study medicine, what then? 9

One evening during self-study, Fang Yuan passed her a little note. It said: "Don't forget your Yinxu!" Underneath she had drawn the oracle bone character for "eye", which is shaped like an eye, though her drawing looked nothing like one. Chen Jing read it and laughed out loud. It was the first time she had laughed that month. 10

The Mock Exam

In December the whole city held its first mock exam. 11

11 成绩出来那天，王老师把年级排名贴在了教室门口，大家都挤过去看。陈静[†]从上往下找，找了很久，才在一百二十名左右看到了自己的名字。上一次考试，她还在前五十名。

12 她的数学只考了八十多分，比平时低了三十多分。最后两道大题，她明明会做，可是一看时间不够了，手就开始出汗，越着急越错。方圆[‡]这次反而考得特别好，进了年级前三十名。同学们围着方圆说她厉害，方圆却看了看陈静，没有说话。

13 那天晚上开家长会[§]，妈妈请了假，坐在陈静的座位上。会开完了，方圆的妈妈拉着陈静的妈妈在门外聊天。不知道怎么就说到了大学专业。方圆想帮陈静说几句好话，就说：“阿姨，陈静对历史特别感兴趣，她以后想学考古[¶]，她懂得可多了……”话还没说完，陈静妈妈的脸色就变了。

† 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
‡ 方圆 *Fāng Yuán* Fang Yuan
§ 家长会 *jiāzhǎnghuì* parents meeting
¶ 考古 *kǎogǔ* archaeology

The day the results came out, Mr Wang posted the year-group ranking by the classroom door, and everyone crowded over to look. Chen Jing searched from the top down for a long time before she found her name, somewhere around 120th place. In the last exam she had been in the top fifty. 11

She scored only a little over eighty in maths, more than thirty points below her usual. She knew perfectly well how to do the last two long problems, but the moment she saw she was running out of time, her hands began to sweat, and the more anxious she got, the more mistakes she made. Fang Yuan, on the other hand, did especially well this time and made the top thirty of the year. Classmates gathered round Fang Yuan telling her how brilliant she was, but Fang Yuan just glanced at Chen Jing and said nothing. 12

That evening there was a parents' meeting. Her mother took time off work and sat in Chen Jing's seat. When the meeting was over, Fang Yuan's mother kept Chen Jing's mother chatting outside the door. Somehow the talk turned to university majors. Fang Yuan wanted to put in a good word for Chen Jing, so she said, "Auntie, Chen Jing is really interested in history. She wants to study archaeology later, and she knows so much about it..." Before she had even finished, the look on Chen Jing's mother's face changed. 13

14 回家的路上，妈妈一句话也没说。到了家，她才说：“考古†？就是在外面挖‡土的那种？你知道这种专业毕业以后能干什么吗？”陈静§低着头说：“我喜欢。”“喜欢能当饭吃吗？”妈妈的声音大了起来，“你这次考成这样，还有时间想这些？”陈静什么也没说，回到自己的房间，关上了门。

15 第二天，陈静把桌子往旁边搬了搬，不跟方圆¶说话了。方圆好几次想跟她解释，她都装作没听见。她觉得，最好的朋友把她最大的秘密说了出去。方圆的眼睛红红的，陈静看到了，心里不免有点儿难受，可她还是一句话也没说。

† 考古 *kǎogǔ* archaeology
‡ 挖 *wā* to dig
§ 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
¶ 方圆 *Fāng Yuán* Fang Yuan

On the way home her mother did not say a word. Only when they got home 14
did she speak: "Archaeology? The kind where you dig in the dirt out in the open? Do you know what you can do with a degree like that?" Chen Jing looked down and said, "I like it." "Can liking something put food on the table?" Her mother's voice rose. "You did this badly in the exam, and you have time to think about things like that?" Chen Jing said nothing at all. She went back to her room and shut the door.

The next day Chen Jing moved her desk a little to the side and stopped 15
speaking to Fang Yuan. Fang Yuan tried several times to explain, but each time Chen Jing pretended not to hear. She felt that her best friend had given away her biggest secret. Fang Yuan's eyes were red. Chen Jing saw it and could not help feeling a little bad, but she still did not say a word.

妈妈的计划

16 寒假只有十天。妈妈给陈静[1]报了一个数学补习班[2]，又在网上查了很多资料。一天晚上，她拿着一张纸走进陈静的房间。纸上写满了学校和专业的名字：郑州大学[3]医学，河南财经政法大学[4]金融学[5]……每一个后面都写着去年的录取分数。

17 “妈妈都帮你看好了，”妈妈说，“学医最好，哪怕辛苦一点儿，也是个铁饭碗[6]。不行的话就学金融[7]，以后去银行上班，也不错。”陈静看着那张纸，问：“妈，您有没有问过我想学什么？”妈妈停了一下：“我这么做，不都是为了你好吗？”

1 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
2 补习班 *bǔxíbān* cram class
3 郑州大学 *Zhèngzhōu Dàxué* Zhengzhou University
4 河南财经政法大学 *Hénán Cáijīng Zhèngfǎ Dàxué* Henan University of Economics and Law
5 金融学 *jīnróngxué* finance (as a subject)
6 铁饭碗 *tiěfànwǎn* iron rice bowl, a secure job
7 金融 *jīnróng* finance

Mother's Plan

The winter holiday was only ten days long. Her mother signed her up for 16
a maths cram class and looked up lots of information online. One evening she walked into Chen Jing's room holding a sheet of paper. It was covered with the names of universities and majors: Medicine at Zhengzhou University, Finance at Henan University of Economics and Law… Next to each one was last year's admission score.

"I've looked into it all for you," her mother said. "Medicine is best. Even if 17
it's a bit hard, it's an iron rice bowl, a job for life. If that doesn't work out, study finance and work in a bank later. That's not bad either." Chen Jing looked at the sheet and asked, "Mum, have you ever asked me what I want to study?" Her mother paused. "Isn't everything I do for your own good?"

18 那天夜里，陈静[†]听见妈妈在客厅里给爸爸打电话：“……她怎么就不明白呢？我在医院干了二十年，见过多少年轻人找不到工作……我不想让她走弯路……”妈妈的声音越来越低，最后好像哭了。陈静坐在床上，抱着自己的腿，第一次觉得妈妈也很累。

19 春节以后，倒计时[‡]牌上的数字变成了一百多。陈静比以前更努力了。她把模拟[§]考试里每一道做错的题都抄在本子上，一遍一遍地做。慢慢地，她发现数学并不可怕，可怕的是自己的紧张。三月的第二次模拟考试，她回到了年级前六十名。王老师在她的试卷上写了一句话：“总算找回自己了。”

20 四月的一个下午，突然下起了大雨。陈静没带伞，站在教学楼门口发呆。忽然，一把蓝色的伞举到了她的头上，是方圆[¶]。

† 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
‡ 倒计时 *dàojìshí* countdown
§ 模拟 *mónǐ* mock, simulated
¶ 方圆 *Fāng Yuán* Fang Yuan

That night Chen Jing heard her mother on the phone to her father in the living room: "...Why doesn't she understand? I've worked at the hospital for twenty years, and I've seen so many young people who can't find a job... I don't want her to take the long way round..." Her mother's voice grew lower and lower, and in the end it sounded as if she was crying. Chen Jing sat on her bed hugging her knees, and for the first time she felt that her mother was tired too. 18

After the Spring Festival, the number on the countdown board dropped to just over a hundred. Chen Jing worked harder than ever. She copied every problem she had got wrong in the mock exam into her notebook and worked through them again and again. Slowly she discovered that maths was not frightening at all; what was frightening was her own nerves. In the second mock exam in March, she was back in the top sixty of the year. Mr Wang wrote one line on her paper: "At last you've found yourself again." 19

One afternoon in April, it suddenly began to pour. Chen Jing had no umbrella and stood staring blankly at the door of the classroom building. Suddenly a blue umbrella was held over her head. It was Fang Yuan. 20

两个人走在雨里，都没有先说话。快到校门的时候，方圆[†]小声说：“对不起。那天我真的只是想帮你……其实我也有我的压力。我爸说，我要是考不上好大学，就得再读一年。”陈静[‡]这才知道，原来方圆每天大声说笑，心里也一样害怕。她停下来，说：“我也应该说对不起。毕竟，你是唯一一个支持我的人。”两个人站在雨里，又哭又笑。

六月七日

倒计时[§]牌上的数字终于变成了“1”。六月六日下午，学校放假了，同学们把桌子上的书全都搬回了家。教室一下子空了，只剩下墙上那个红色的“1”。王老师站在讲台上，看了大家很久，最后只说了一句：“平时怎么做，明天就怎么做。”

† 方圆 *Fāng Yuán* Fang Yuan
‡ 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
§ 倒计时 *dàojìshí* countdown

The two of them walked in the rain, and neither spoke first. Near the school gate, Fang Yuan said quietly, "I'm sorry. That day I really only wanted to help you... The truth is, I'm under pressure too. My dad says if I don't get into a good university, I'll have to repeat the year." Only then did Chen Jing realise that Fang Yuan, for all her loud talk and laughter every day, was just as afraid inside. She stopped and said, "I should say sorry too. After all, you're the only one who has ever stood by me." The two of them stood in the rain, crying and laughing at once. 20

The Seventh of June

At last the number on the countdown board became "1". On the afternoon of the sixth of June, school let out, and everyone carried all the books on their desks home. All at once the classroom was empty, with only the red "1" left on the wall. Mr Wang stood at the front, looked at them all for a long time, and in the end said just one thing: "Tomorrow, do it the way you always do." 21

22 七号早上六点，陈静[†]就醒了，其实她一夜都没睡好。妈妈专门请了两天假，早饭准备了一根油条[‡]和两个鸡蛋。“一根油条，两个鸡蛋，一百分！”妈妈笑着说。陈静本来紧张得吃不下，听了这句话，还是笑着吃完了。

23 八点，她到了考场[§]外面。校门口站满了家长，有的穿着红衣服，有的手里拿着花。警察在路口指挥交通，附近的人说话都很小声。八点半，考生开始进考场。陈静又检查了一遍准考证[¶]和身份证，回头看了一眼。妈妈站在人群里，向她举起了手。

24 九点，语文考试开始。陈静一看作文题目，就看到了一个词：“传承[*]”。她的心一下子安静了下来。她写了爷爷，写了殷墟[#]，写了那些在土里等了三千年的字。

† 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
‡ 油条 *yóutiáo* deep-fried dough stick
§ 考场 *kǎochǎng* examination site
¶ 准考证 *zhǔnkǎozhèng* exam admission ticket
* 传承 *chuánchéng* heritage, passing down
殷墟 *Yīnxū* Yinxu, ruins of the late Shang capital

On the morning of the seventh, Chen Jing was awake by six; in fact she had hardly slept all night. Her mother had taken two days off specially, and for breakfast she made one dough stick and two eggs. "One dough stick and two eggs: a hundred points!" her mother said with a smile. Chen Jing had been too nervous to eat, but when she heard that, she laughed and ate it all. 22

At eight o'clock she reached the exam site. The school gate was crowded with parents, some dressed in red for luck, some holding flowers. Police were directing traffic at the crossroads, and everyone nearby spoke in low voices. At half past eight the candidates began to enter. Chen Jing checked her admission ticket and ID card once more and looked back. Her mother stood in the crowd and raised a hand to her. 23

At nine the Chinese exam began. As soon as Chen Jing looked at the essay question, she saw one word: "heritage". All at once her heart grew calm. She wrote about her grandfather, about Yinxu, about the characters that had waited in the earth for three thousand years. 24

24 十一点半，铃声响了，她放下笔，才发现手心全是汗。

25 下午三点，考数学，这是陈静[†]最怕的一门。做到最后两道大题的时候，她看了看表，还有四十分钟。她的手又开始出汗了。她停下笔，深吸了一口气，在心里对自己说：哪怕这道题做不出来，也不是世界末日[‡]。慢慢地，她平静了下来。五点，她交了卷，走出考场[§]。太阳很大，她总算松了一口气。

26 八号上午考综合，下午考英语。下午五点，最后一门考试结束了。考生们从校门里走出来，门口的家长们都为他们鼓掌。方圆[¶]在门口等她，一下子抱住了她。“结束了！”方圆大声喊。“结束了。”陈静说。她回头看着学校的大门，不免有点儿舍不得。

† 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
‡ 世界末日 *shìjiè mòrì* the end of the world
§ 考场 *kǎochǎng* examination site
¶ 方圆 *Fāng Yuán* Fang Yuan

At half past eleven the bell rang. She put down her pen and only then noticed that her palms were soaked with sweat. 24

At three in the afternoon came maths, the subject Chen Jing feared most. When she reached the last two long problems, she glanced at the clock: forty minutes left. Her hands began to sweat again. She put down her pen, took a deep breath and told herself: even if I can't solve this one, it's not the end of the world. Slowly she calmed down. At five she handed in her paper and walked out. The sun was blazing, and at last she could breathe a sigh of relief. 25

On the morning of the eighth came the combined-subjects paper, and in the afternoon English. At five in the afternoon the last exam was over. As the candidates streamed out of the gate, the parents outside all applauded them. Fang Yuan was waiting for her at the gate and threw her arms around her. "It's over!" Fang Yuan shouted. "It's over," said Chen Jing. She looked back at the school gate and could not help feeling a little sad to leave it behind. 26

填志愿

27 六月底，成绩出来了。陈静[†]考了六百一十多分，比她最好的一次模拟[‡]考试还高了二十分。妈妈看着手机上的分数，高兴得哭了，马上给爸爸打电话，又给奶奶打电话。

28 可是真正难的事情，现在才开始。成绩出来以后，还要填志愿。这个分数，可以去郑州大学[§]学医，也可以在这所大学学考古[¶]。妈妈又拿出了那张纸，上面已经画了很多圈。“你看，都是郑州大学，为什么不学医呢？”

29 那几天，家里特别安静。妈妈没有再提学医，陈静也不提考古。电脑开着，填志愿的网站也开着，可是谁都没有按下“提交[*]”。陈静知道，除非她自己说出来，否则这张表永远都是妈妈的表。

† 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
‡ 模拟 *mónǐ* mock, simulated
§ 郑州大学 *Zhèngzhōu Dàxué* Zhengzhou University
¶ 考古 *kǎogǔ* archaeology
* 提交 *tíjiāo* to submit

Filling In the Application

At the end of June, the results came out. Chen Jing scored just over 610, twenty points higher than her best mock exam. Her mother looked at the score on her phone and cried with joy, then rang her father straight away, and then Grandma. 27

But the truly hard part was only beginning. Once the scores were out, she still had to fill in her application choices. With this score she could study medicine at Zhengzhou University, or archaeology at that same university. Her mother brought out that sheet of paper again, now covered in circles. "Look, it's Zhengzhou University either way. Why not study medicine?" 28

For the next few days the flat was very quiet. Her mother stopped mentioning medicine, and Chen Jing did not mention archaeology. The computer was on and the application website was open, but nobody pressed "Submit". Chen Jing knew that unless she spoke up herself, this form would always be her mother's form. 29

30 离截止[†]时间还有两天的那个晚上，陈静[‡]终于走到妈妈面前。她拿出一个旧本子，里面贴着她从小到大[§]剪下来的考古[¶]新闻，还有一张照片：七岁的她和爷爷站在殷墟[*]门口。“妈，”她的声音不大，可是很坚定，“我知道您是为我好，我也知道学考古不容易，可能挣不了很多钱。可是我想学。哪怕以后很辛苦，我也不会后悔。要是我听您的去学医，我怕我一辈子都会想：当初要是试一试就好了。”

31 妈妈翻着那个本子，翻了很久。本子的第一页，是陈静上小学时写的一句话：“我长大了要去找三千年前的人。”字写得大大小小的，有几个字还是用拼音[#]写的。妈妈看着看着，忽然笑了，眼睛却红了。“你这孩子，怎么什么都不跟妈说呢？”她说，“妈年轻的时候也想当老师，可是家里人说当护士稳定，我就听了。

† 截止 *jiézhǐ* deadline
‡ 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
§ 从小到大 *cóngxiǎo dàodà* from childhood on
¶ 考古 *kǎogǔ* archaeology
* 殷墟 *Yīnxū* Yinxu, ruins of the late Shang capital
拼音 *pīnyīn* pinyin

One evening, two days before the deadline, Chen Jing finally went to her 30
mother. She brought out an old notebook. Pasted inside were archaeology news stories she had cut out ever since she was little, and a photo: herself at seven, standing with her grandfather at the entrance to Yinxu. "Mum," she said, her voice quiet but firm, "I know you want what's best for me, and I know archaeology isn't easy. I might not earn much money. But I want to study it. Even if it's hard later on, I won't regret it. If I do as you say and study medicine, I'm afraid I'll spend my whole life thinking: if only I had tried back then."

Her mother leafed through the notebook for a long time. On the first page 31
was a sentence Chen Jing had written in primary school: "When I grow up I will go and find the people of three thousand years ago." The characters were all different sizes, and a few were still written in pinyin. As her mother read, she suddenly smiled, though her eyes had gone red. "You silly girl, why do you never tell me anything?" she said. "When I was young I wanted to be a teacher too, but my family said nursing was more secure, so I listened.

31 这么多年，也不能说后悔，可是……”她没有说下去。

32 那天晚上，妈妈坐在陈静[†]旁边，看着她在第一志愿里填上了：郑州大学[‡]，考古学[§]。陈静的手放在鼠标上，回头看了看妈妈。妈妈点了点头：“你总算愿意把想法告诉妈了。按吧。”陈静按下了“提交[¶]”。电脑上出现了四个字：提交成功。

33 八月，录取通知书总算到了。妈妈把它放在客厅里最容易看见的地方，见人就说：“我女儿要去学考古[*]了，以后要去找三千年前的人呢。”陈静听了，脸红红的，心里却很甜。墙上的倒计时[#]牌早就不在了，可是她知道，属于她自己的日子，才刚刚开始。

† 陈静 *Chén Jìng* Chen Jing
‡ 郑州大学 *Zhèngzhōu Dàxué* Zhengzhou University
§ 考古学 *kǎogǔxué* archaeology (as a subject)
¶ 提交 *tíjiāo* to submit
* 考古 *kǎogǔ* archaeology
\# 倒计时 *dàojìshí* countdown

All these years, I can't really say I regret it, but…" She did not go on. 31

That evening her mother sat beside Chen Jing and watched her enter her first 32
choice: Zhengzhou University, Archaeology. With her hand on the mouse, Chen Jing turned to look at her mother. Her mother nodded. "At last you're willing to tell me what you really think. Go on, press it." Chen Jing pressed "Submit". Four characters appeared on the computer: "Submitted successfully."

In August, the admission letter finally arrived. Her mother put it where it 33
was easiest to see in the living room and told everyone she met, "My daughter is going to study archaeology. One day she's going to find the people of three thousand years ago!" Chen Jing blushed when she heard it, but inside she felt sweet and warm. The countdown board on the wall was long gone, but she knew that the days that belonged to her were only just beginning.